



Legislation plants seeds for community gardens statewide



Michele Brown, Searchlight Betterment Organization and works for Clark County shows one of the many garden beds at the Searchlight Community Garden where it has already produced some vegetables which includes zucchini, jalapeños, carrots and many more in Searchlight, Nevada on Wednesday, September 26, 2024. Photo by: [Brian Ramos](#)

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With thousands of Nevadans struggling to access fresh food in their neighborhoods, a new bill seeks to transform vacant lots across the state into thriving community gardens and urban farms.

More than 200,000 Nevadans live in so-called food deserts, primarily in urban areas where over 90% of the state's population resides, according to UNR.

Assembly Bill 405 would shift from fragmented local approaches to a coordinated statewide strategy with dedicated programs and resources aimed at expanding food access.

The legislation includes more than \$165,000 in funding for the 2025-2027 biennium to sustain the programs and expand their reach throughout Nevada communities.

The bill requires the Agriculture Department to establish a program to assist in developing community gardens in areas of food insecurity. It also calls for funding the efforts further through gifts, donations or grants.

Food deserts have become increasingly common throughout Nevada. The U.S. Department of Agriculture defines these areas as low-income communities where residents must travel substantial distances to reach supermarkets — half a mile to a mile in urban areas, and 10 to 20 miles in rural regions.

Community-based agricultural initiatives are already demonstrating success across the state.

Notable examples include Zion Urban Farm, a 1.5-acre project in North Las Vegas, and Flint Street Farm in downtown Reno, which has converted a former parking lot into productive growing space that strengthens local food security.

“Most of us are fortunate to live a short drive away from a grocery store where we can access a variety of affordable and healthy foods,” said Assemblymember Tanya Flanagan, D-Las Vegas, the bill’s primary sponsor. “Unfortunately, people who do not often rely on convenience stores or unhealthy options.”

During previous legislative sessions, lawmakers enacted measures to support community gardens, Flanagan said. In 2021, Gov. Steve Sisolak signed Senate Bill 297 into law to provide partial tax abatements for community gardens and urban farms.

“The benefits of urban farms and community gardens are numerous,” Flanagan said. “We are all aware of the health benefits associated with having access to fresh fruits and vegetables.”

Community gardens offer multiple benefits, according to Flanagan. Economically, they transform vacant lots and abandoned structures into productive farms that can boost property values.

From an environmental perspective, these gardens help eliminate hazards, enhance soil quality and decrease stormwater runoff. On the cultural and social front, they create valuable spaces where people can form connections.

“My father’s 86 and every day one of his greatest joys is going to the community garden in the neighborhood to help other seniors learn how to grow things,” Flanagan said.

Rural towns and small tourism areas like Cal-Nev-Ari and Pioche can benefit from community gardens, said Kyle Myers, president of the Searchlight Betterment Community.

Searchlight started a community garden with help from UNR Extension. The garden sits near the town's only school. The proximity allows schoolchildren to learn about planting crops.

Searchlight, an unincorporated town of fewer than 500 people, has no supermarket. The town sits about halfway between Boulder City and Laughlin.

Crops in the Searchlight garden include carrots, cucumbers, peppers, beets and zucchinis.

Myers said his group initially allocated \$7,000 for materials for the garden. Clark County allows the town to tap into its water line to irrigate the garden.

“(The bill) would be an excellent program to help all the small communities throughout the state,” Myers said. “The idea is gonna grow like a weed.”